Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.0.0-beta, 15-Apr-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
- Distributed at:
  https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
- © 2026 Bill Wetzel - Licensed under CC BY 4.0
  https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/

1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Launching

- **`helix`**
- **`helix`** `<file>`
- **`helix`** `<file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- **`helix`** `–help`
- **`hx`** `in some distributions or by alias`

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

`:wq`	– write current buffer and quit
`:wq <file>`	– write current buffer to <file> and quit
`:wqa`	– write all buffer(s) and quit
`:q`	– quit current buffer, exits if last

2.1.2 Files

`:o <file>`	– open <file> in new buffer
`:w <file>`	– write current buffer to <file>
`:hs <file>`	– open/create <file> in new horizontal split
`:vs <file>`	– open/create <file> in new vertical split
`␣wf`	– open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
`␣wF`	– open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
`gf`	– open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.
`␣f`	– open file picker at LSP workspace root
`␣F`	– open file picker at current working directory
`␣g`	– open changed file picker

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

`<enter>`	– open selected in current view
`Ctrl-s`	– open selected in new horizontal split
`Ctrl-v`	– open selected in new vertical split

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

`:n`	– create new scratch buffer
`:bc`	– close current buffer
`:bca`	– close all buffers
`:bco`	– close all but current buffer
`:bn`	– next buffer
`␣b`	– open buffer picker
`ga`	– go to last accessed/alternate buffer
`gm`	– go to last modified/alternate buffer
`gn`	– go to next buffer
`gp`	– go to previous buffer

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and **`␣w`** are synonymous.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
                v – enter select mode
                3 – select 3
                w – words
                d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
               wd – delete word
               xc – change line
               %y – yank entire file
```

1.5 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape metachars with backslash when searching for literal value.

```
                . – any character
                * – zero or more
                + – one or more
                ? – zero or one / lazy modifier
                ^ – start of line / negation in class
                $ – end of line
              ( ) – capture group
              [ ] – character class
              { } – repetition count
                | – alternation
                \ – escape character itself
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

```
            u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
    Alt-u / Alt-U – move backward / forward in tree history
      :ear / :lat – move backward / forward in history by step count or time
                    span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
        <nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
              Esc – return to normal mode
```

```
     ␣ws / ␣wv  – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
    ␣wns / ␣wnv – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
            ␣wq – close current split
            ␣wo – close all but current split
            ␣ww – next split

      ␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down / right
      ␣wH/J/K/L – swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
            ␣wt – transpose split
```

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
                Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc

            zz, zc – align to center
                zt – align to top
                zb – align to bottom
                zm – align to middle horizontally
                zj – scroll down
                zk – scroll up
```

2.1.5 Help

```
            :tutor – open tutorial
                ␣? – open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
            h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
             gh, g| – beginning of line
             <nn>g| – column <nn>
                 gl – end of line
                 gg – top of file
     <nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
                 ge – bottom of file
                 gw – two-char labels on words, label to go to word

                 g.– to last modification in current file
                 gj – down textual line
                 gk – up textual line

                 gs – first non-white-space char
                 gt – top of screen
                 gc – middle of screen
                 gb – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
gd – go to definition
gy – go to type definition
gr – go to references
gi – go to implementation

]d – next diagnostic
[d – prior diagnostic
]D – last diagnostic
[D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f – to next, prior function
]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
]T, [T – to next, prior test
]a, [a – to next, prior arg
]c, [c – to next, prior comment
]g, [g – to next, prior change
]G, [G – to last, first change

Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax tree
Alt-b – move to start of parent node in syntax tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
%  – select whole file
Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor at end)
Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
Alt-i – shrink selection
;  – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
v   – toggle select mode
Esc – return to normal
)   – cycle primary selection forward
(   – cycle primary selection backward
Alt-, – remove primary selection
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
s<regex> – matches become selections
S        – split on match
Alt-s    – split on newlines
C, Alt-C – add selection below, above
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
&          – align on primary cursor
Alt-<minus> – merge selections
Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selections
,          – remove all except primary selection
Alt-,      – remove primary selection
( / )      – rotate primary backwards / forwards
Alt-( / Alt-) – rotate content backward / forward
K          – keep selections matching the regex
Alt-K      – remove selections matching the regex
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
i   – before selection
a   – after selection
I   – at start of line
A   – at end of line
o   – add line and insert below cursor
O   – add line and insert above cursor
Esc – end insert (return to normal)
.   – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the object indicated by <ch>
                  below:
          w / W – word / WORD
              p – paragraph
   (, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
              m –  closest surround pair
              f – function
              t – type or class
              a – argument/parameter
              c – comment
              T – test
              g – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
w / W – to start of next word / WORD
e / E – to end of current word / WORD
b / B – to start of current word / WORD
    x – current line, extend by line
    X – extend to line
Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
   ]p – to next paragraph
   [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node
Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
      Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

```
   ]␣ – newline below
   [␣ – newline above
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
     d – selection -> yank buf, delete selection
Alt-d – delete, no save
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.4 Change

```
     c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
Alt-c – change, no save
     = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
> – Indent line(s) containing selection
< – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
     ~ – change case
     ` – set lowercase
Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
        ␣C – Toggle block comment
  ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
                J – join lines in a selection
          Alt-J – join lines inside selection and select the inserted space
       <under> – trim whitespace from selection
:reflow <width> – wrap selection to <width>, default 80
          :sort – sort ranges in selection
        :format – format file using external formatter / language server
```

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
                y – selection -> yank buf
                p – paste yank buf after the cursor
                P – paste yank buf before the cursor
              ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
              ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
        ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
              ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
          r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
                R – replace selection with yank buf
                " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.8 Search

```
        /<regex> – search forward for regex
        ?<regex> – search backward for regex
            n, N – next, previous match
                * – search for current selection, respect word boundaries
          Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
          "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
        "<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
        "<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
        "<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
        "<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
        "<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
        Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
        Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
        Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
                      Ctrl-s – commit undo checkpoint
                      Ctrl-x – autocomplete
                      Ctrl-r – insert a register content
          Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> – delete previous word
            Alt-d, Alt-<del> – delete next word
                      Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                      Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp> – delete previous char
               Ctrl-d, <del> – delete next char
             Ctrl-j, <enter> – insert new line
  <Up> <Down> <Left> <Right> – usual meaning but discouraged
  <PageUp> <PageDown> <Home>
                       <End>
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
                 Esc, Ctrl-c – close prompt
                    <enter> – open selected
                      <tab> – select next completion item
                  <backtab> – select previous completion item
                      Alt-b – backward a word
                      Ctrl-b – backward a char
                      Alt-f – forward a word
                      Ctrl-f – forward a char
                      Ctrl-e – to prompt end
                      Ctrl-a – to prompt start
         Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> – delete previous word
           Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> – delete next word
                      Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                      Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
              <bksp>, Ctrl-h – delete previous char
               <del>, Ctrl-d – delete next char
                      Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc cursor (may be
                               changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
                      Ctrl-p – select previous history
                      Ctrl-n – select next history
                      Ctrl-r – insert the content of the register selected
                               by following input char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
    Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> – previous entry
        <tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> – next entry
                      <Home> – to first entry
                       <End> – to last entry
```

```
␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
mm – go to matching delim
mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
| – replace selection(s) with output
Alt-| – ignore output
! – insert output before each selection(s)
Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
$ – keep selection(s) where command returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

```
␣G – debug - experimental
␣k – show documentation for item under cursor
␣s – open document symbol picker
␣S – open workspace symbol picker
␣d – open document diagnostics picker
␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
␣r – rename symbol
␣a – apply code action
␣h – select symbol references for symbol under cursor
```

2.15 Editor Configuration

```
:config-open – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace config file
:config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.16 Miscellaneous

```
␣' – open last picker
␣/ – open global search in workspace folder picker
```

```
Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
<enter> – open selected
Alt-<enter> – open selected in the background without
              closing the picker
Ctrl-s – open horizontally
Ctrl-v – open vertically
Ctrl-t – toggle preview
Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
Ctrl-u – scroll up
Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
<enter> – close menu and accept completion
Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
Alt-p – previous signature
Alt-n – next signature
```